in Aid to Civil Authority to restore the situation. Schools and colleges can be closed but essential services have to continue to function, for which we would be the last resort. As it transpired, our efforts at force protection paid off, not as envisaged, but in being able to respond to the crisis in Eastern Ladakh. It is only because we were battleworthy that we could rapidly mobilize units when the need arose, since steps such as screening of troops, restricting leave, placing local markets out of bounds, etc., had already been instituted.

At about the same time, the Centre for Land Warfare Studies (CLAWS) organized an international webinar, 'Pragyan Conclave', with the theme of 'Contours of Future Wars and Counter Measures'. Covid was rearing its head and many of the international speakers had to cancel at the last minute. During my talk, I brought out that, 'We are witnessing conflicts increasingly transcending time, space and force dimensions, and enveloping new frontiers.' I spoke about how technology is driving doctrine and that the mainstays of the twentieth-century battlefield, the main battle tanks, large surface ships and manned aircraft, might become irrelevant. This immediately created a furore as it hit at the very fundamental level—the '*raison d'être*' of the Services. I brought out that we could be modern, yet irrelevant at the same time in the face of changing threat perceptions.[9] Christine Fair, an American political scientist and noted author, had also attended and I had an opportunity to interact with her a couple of days later, in the Chief's Lounge at South Block. It was supposed to be a courtesy call, but like a true journalist, she asked some very searching questions with respect to our defence preparedness and multiplicity of equipment in our stocks, which did set me thinking about our large inventories and long supply chains. I clarified that this was because of our imports from multiple countries and the L1

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation